



United States
Attorney's Office
Southern District of California



Couple Charged in Cross-Border Identity Theft and Immigration Fraud Scheme

Wednesday, September 3, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Southern District of California

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SAN DIEGO – Luis Enrique Villegas Brownell and his girlfriend, Kassandra Sanchez, were charged in federal court with stealing the identity of Sanchez's brother to commit a variety of federal crimes in the United States.

According to the indictment, Villegas, a Mexican citizen without legal status in the United States, and Sanchez, a U.S. citizen, conspired to steal identification documents belonging to Sanchez's brother, identified in court records as J.D.S. Villegas then used those documents to falsely pose as a U.S. citizen and apply for entry into the United States.

Once in the United States, Villegas went to the California DMV and provided false information under penalty of perjury to obtain a state ID card in the name of J.D.S. but bearing Villegas's photo and thumbprint. He and Sanchez then used the fraudulent ID to impersonate J.D.S. and cross the border unlawfully for more than a year. Prosecutors say that Villegas crossed more than 50 times in the past 17 months, often with Sanchez driving to the port of entry and presenting the fraudulent ID to border officers. Port-of-entry video shows Sanchez lying to officers about Villegas's birthplace and concealing his true identity.

According to court documents, the real J.D.S. applied for entry to the United States at the San Ysidro Port of Entry in April 2025 but was unable to cross due to the theft of his identity. During that encounter, J.D.S. reported to border officers that his sister, Sanchez, asked for his identity documents to smuggle her Mexican boyfriend into the United States. When he declined, she took them without his consent.

The government also alleges Villegas used J.D.S.'s identity to commit other federal crimes, including smuggling an undocumented immigrant through the San Ysidro Port of Entry and fraudulently obtaining California public benefits such as Medi-Cal.

Sanchez allegedly committed the offenses while on supervised release for a prior federal conviction in the Southern District of California relating to an arrest for smuggling methamphetamine into the United States.

This case is being prosecuted by Assistant U.S. Attorney Patrick C. Swan.

<u>DEFENDANTS</u>		<u>Case Number: 25cr3286-BTM</u>
Luis Enrique Villegas Brownell	Age: 20	Tijuana, Mexico
Kassandra Sanchez	Age: 23	San Diego, California

SUMMARY OF CHARGES

- Conspiracy – Title 18, U.S.C., Section 371
- Maximum penalty: Five years in prison and \$250,000 fine
- Conspiracy – Title 18, U.S.C., Section 1028(f)
- Maximum penalty: Fifteen years in prison and \$250,000 fine
- Unlawful Production of Identification Document – Title 18, U.S.C., Sections 1028(a)(1), (b)(1)(A)(ii), and 2
- Maximum penalty: Fifteen years in prison and \$250,000 fine
- False Personation in Immigration Matter – Title 18, U.S.C., Sections 1546(a) and 2
- Maximum penalty: Ten years in prison and \$250,000 fine
- False Claim to U.S. Citizenship – Title 18, U.S.C., Section 911
- Maximum penalty: Three years in prison and \$250,000 fine
- Aggravated Identity Theft – Title 18, U.S.C., Section 1028A(a)(1)
- Maximum penalty: Mandatory two years in prison, served consecutive to any other sentence

INVESTIGATING AGENCIES

- Homeland Security Investigations
- U.S. Customs and Border Protection

*The charges and allegations contained in an indictment or complaint are merely accusations, and the defendants are considered innocent unless and until proven guilty.

Contact

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